

SC Mukhiya Survey - LSE Dissertation

Module 0 — Introduction and verbal consent

Enumerator: Namaste! My name is __, I am speaking from Patna from CK Singh Management. We are doing a research with a student from the London School of Economics. Through this survey, we want to learn about the experience of working as a Scheduled Caste Mukhiya in Bihar—what is your daily life like in this position, and what challenges do you face in your social and political lives that hinder your work. We also want to inform you that we are not affiliated with any government organization, nor is this an evaluation of you as a Mukhiya. This is a survey, primarily intended to hear your experience from your own perspective. The information provided in this survey is kept confidential and will not be shared with anyone. It will be used solely for this research.

Do you agree to take part in this interview?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Enumerator: thank the respondent and end the interview here.

Module A — Respondent and panchayat profile

» A1. Respondent identification

Name of the elected mukhiya

Enumerator: record from the sample frame and confirm with the respondent.

Unique ID of the respondent:

Enter the unique id of the respondent from the sample list.

Re-enter the Unique ID of the respondent.

Are you the elected mukhiya yourself, or answering on their behalf?

☐ I am the elected mukhiya

☐ I am answering on behalf of the elected mukhiya

Gender of the elected mukhiya

Don't ask this question. Only record from your judgement.

☐ Male

☐ Female

What is your relationship to the elected mukhiya?

- | | | |
|---|---|---------------------------------------|
| ☐ Husband | ☐ Father | ☐ Father-in-law |
| ☐ Son | ☐ Brother | ☐ Brother-in-law |
| ☐ Other male relative | ☐ Other female relative | ☐ Other (specify) |

Other relationship (specify)

Gender of the respondent*Don't ask this question. Only record from your judgement.*

- ☐ Male
- ☐ Female

Caste category of the elected mukhiya

- | | | |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|--|
| ☐ General | ☐ BC-1 (EBC) | ☐ BC-2 (BC) |
| ☐ Scheduled Caste | ☐ Scheduled Tribe | ☐ Other (please specify) |

Specify why participant doesn't belong to listed caste category:

Caste / jāti of the elected mukhiya

Caste / jāti of the elected mukhiya (name)

» A2. Panchayat characteristics**Number of revenue villages in your gram panchayat**

Approximate total population of the panchayat

Approximate SC population share

- ☐ Less than 10%
- ☐ 10–15%
- ☐ 15–20%
- ☐ More than 20%
- ☐ Not sure

Do you belong to the largest / main village of the panchayat?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Which caste group is the most dominant / influential in your panchayat?

» A3. Tenure and background

How many times have you stood for election?

How many terms have you served as mukhiya (including the current one)?

Highest level of education completed

- | | | |
|---|---|---|
| ☐ No formal schooling | ☐ Primary | ☐ Middle |
| ☐ Secondary (10th) | ☐ Higher secondary (12th) | ☐ Graduate or above |

Main source of household income

- | | | |
|---|--|--------------------------------------|
| ☐ Agricultural labour on others' land | ☐ Own cultivation | ☐ Small business |
| ☐ Salaried job | ☐ Government scheme work | ☐ Other |

Module B — Political entry and pathway

Has anyone in your family held a panchayat position before you (mukhiya, ward member, sarpanch)?

One or more options may be selected.

- ☐ No one
- ☐ Father
- ☐ Father-in-law
- ☐ Spouse
- ☐ Sibling
- ☐ Other relative

Whose idea was it originally that you should contest the mukhiya election?

One or more options may be selected.

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ My own decision | ☐ Family encouraged me |
| ☐ SC community members encouraged me | ☐ An upper-caste leader encouraged me |
| ☐ Former mukhiya or their relatives | ☐ A Dalit rights organization |
| ☐ Other (specify) | ☐ A political party |

Other (specify)

Did you contest with the support of a political party / leader?

- ☐ Yes, formally
- ☐ Yes, informally
- ☐ No, independent

Enumerator note: slow down, use a warm neutral tone, reassure confidentiality before this block. Normalise with 'some mukhiyas tell us...'.

Some mukhiyas tell us that during the election they were asked to withdraw their nomination. Did anything like this happen to you?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Who asked you to withdraw?

One or more options may be selected.

- ☐ Political elite / Bahubali of the panchayat ☐ Opposition candidate
- ☐ Some party / leader ☐ Own family / community ☐ Other (specify)

Other (specify)

Some mukhiyas are offered money, land, or other benefits to step aside or to act according to others' wishes. Was anything like this offered to you?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

During the election, did you or your family face any threats or intimidation?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Without naming anyone, what kind?

Ask gently. Do not ask for names.

- ☐ Verbal threats / cussing ☐ Threats to family
- ☐ Economic threats (work, loans, land) ☐ Physical intimidation
- ☐ Other (specify)

Other (specify)

Module C — Independence and authority in office

(Read aloud) "The next questions are about how work gets done in your panchayat. There are no right or wrong answers. For each task, please tell me who most often does it."

Preparing cheques and financial documents

- ☐ I do it myself ☐ I do it with help from family ☐ The panchayat secretary does it
- ☐ The former mukhiya / family member ☐ The up-mukhiya (deputy) does it
- ☐ A family member does it for me ☐ Someone else (specify)

Someone else (specify)

Deciding the beneficiary list for housing and other schemes

- ☐ I do it myself ☐ I do it with help from family ☐ The panchayat secretary does it
- ☐ The former mukhiya / family member ☐ The up-mukhiya (deputy) does it
- ☐ A family member does it for me ☐ Someone else (specify)

Someone else (specify)

Chairing and running the Gram Sabha meeting

- ☐ I do it myself ☐ I do it with help from family ☐ The panchayat secretary does it
- ☐ The former mukhiya / family member ☐ The up-mukhiya (deputy) does it
- ☐ A family member does it for me ☐ Someone else (specify)

Someone else (specify)

Meeting the BDO or other officials on panchayat work

- ☐ I do it myself ☐ I do it with help from family ☐ The panchayat secretary does it
- ☐ The former mukhiya / family member ☐ The up-mukhiya (deputy) does it
- ☐ A family member does it for me ☐ Someone else (specify)

Someone else (specify)

Representing the panchayat at block-level meetings

- ☐ I do it myself
 ☐ I do it with help from family
 ☐ The panchayat secretary does it
- ☐ The former mukhiya / family member
 ☐ The up-mukhiya (deputy) does it
- ☐ A family member does it for me
 ☐ Someone else (specify)

Someone else (specify)

Deciding which development works get priority

- ☐ I do it myself
 ☐ I do it with help from family
 ☐ The panchayat secretary does it
- ☐ The former mukhiya / family member
 ☐ The up-mukhiya (deputy) does it
- ☐ A family member does it for me
 ☐ Someone else (specify)

Someone else (specify)

Attending to villagers who come with complaints or requests

- ☐ I do it myself
 ☐ I do it with help from family
 ☐ The panchayat secretary does it
- ☐ The former mukhiya / family member
 ☐ The up-mukhiya (deputy) does it
- ☐ A family member does it for me
 ☐ Someone else (specify)

Someone else (specify)

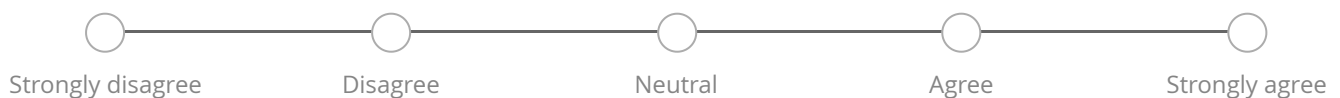
When an important decision has to be made in the panchayat, who makes the final call?

- ☐ I do, independently
 ☐ I do, after consulting others
 ☐ I and the deputy / others jointly
- ☐ Others decide and I formalise it
 ☐ Others decide entirely

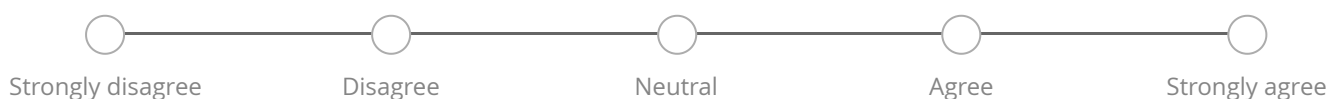
Enumerator: read the options for each statement — Strongly agree / Agree / Neutral / Disagree / Strongly disagree.

» C3. Self-efficacy in the role

I am able to get my decisions implemented even when powerful people disagree.



When someone creates obstacles, I am usually able to find a way to get the work done.



I am confident in my ability to achieve most of the goals I set for myself.

☐ Strongly disagree
 ☐ Disagree
 ☐ Neutral
 ☐ Agree
 ☐ Strongly agree

I can stand my ground when someone tries to pressure me into a decision.

☐ Strongly disagree
 ☐ Disagree
 ☐ Neutral
 ☐ Agree
 ☐ Strongly agree

I feel confident representing my panchayat before government officials.

☐ Strongly disagree
 ☐ Disagree
 ☐ Neutral
 ☐ Agree
 ☐ Strongly agree

Enumerator: this is not a test — record what the respondent knows; 'Not sure' is fine. On knowledge items, do NOT read the options aloud; code the spoken answer.

Do you know whether the mukhiya has the authority to call a Gram Sabha meeting on their own?

Do not read options; code the answer.

- ☐ Yes
☐ No
☐ Not sure

Do you know what a GPDP is?

Do not read options; code the answer.

- ☐ Yes
☐ No
☐ Not sure

Do you know what type the 15th Finance Commission fund is?

Options may be read aloud if needed.

- ☐ Tied
☐ Untied
☐ Both
☐ Not sure

Are you aware of how many standing committees your GP has?

Enter the number. Leave blank if not known.

Are you aware of who gives birth-death certificates to villagers?

Do not read options; code the answer.

- ☐ Mukhiya
- ☐ Secretary
- ☐ Both
- ☐ Not sure

How are PMAY-G beneficiaries mainly selected?

Do not read options; code the answer.

- ☐ Mukhiya chooses freely ☐ Other
- ☐ Survey-based list verified by Gram Sabha ☐ BDO alone chooses
- ☐ Not sure

Module D — Microaggressions

(Read aloud) "Now I would like to ask how people behave towards you in your role as mukhiya. Some SC mukhiyas have shared different experiences. There are no right or wrong answers — I only want to understand your experience."

Now, I will read a few statements. Tell me if this has happened to you since you became mukhiya.

D1. Microinsults — verbal

People have seemed surprised that you can handle the responsibilities of a mukhiya.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

Someone has suggested you got the position only because of reservation, not ability.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

People have questioned whether you have the education or capacity to do the job.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

Someone has questioned whether you have the financial standing to be a leader.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

People suggested that somebody else should hoist the flag in the GP on Independence or Republic Day.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

D2. Microinvalidations — dismissal / denial

People have gone to someone else (a former mukhiya or secretary) for official work that is your responsibility.

-

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

People used caste-based slur targeted towards to you -- directly or indirectly?

-

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

People ignored your suggestions or concerns in panchayat meetings, thinking you lack the education and experience for the job.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

D3. Microassaults — overt caste marking

Enumerator: ask sensitively. Never repeat any caste slur.

At a social or religious function, you were treated differently in matters of food or seating because of your caste.

-

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

You were made to wait, or seated separately, in ways that upper-caste mukhiyas are not.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

In general, how commonly do you think SC mukhiyas in your block or district face this kind of everyday disrespectful treatment?

- ☐ Very common
- ☐ Somewhat common
- ☐ Rare
- ☐ Never

Module E — Backlash

(Read aloud) "Now I want to understand what happens when you try to carry out your work as mukhiya — especially when you take decisions that some people may not like."

E1. Bureaucratic obstruction (institutional)

Officials have refused to meet you or made you come repeatedly for work they would handle quickly for others.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

Your files, applications, or approvals have been delayed without good reason.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

You have been kept in the dark about scheme beneficiary lists or information you are entitled to.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

An official has behaved rudely or with hostility once they realised your caste.

Since you became mukhiya — has this happened?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

How often?

- ☐ Rarely
- ☐ Sometimes
- ☐ Often
- ☐ Very often

Compared to how officials treat upper-caste mukhiyas in your block, how are you treated?

- ☐ Much worse
- ☐ Somewhat worse
- ☐ The same
- ☐ Better
- ☐ Lot better

E2. Obstruction by panchayat-internal actors

Has the former (previous) mukhiya tried to interfere with or undermine your work?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Has the deputy mukhiya (up-mukhiya) or panchayat secretary worked against your decisions?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Have ward members or other elected members refused to cooperate with you?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

E3. Obstruction / hostility by community and elites

Have false accusations, complaints or cases been filed against you to malign your reputation or to stop you from working?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Have upper-caste elites tried to organise people against you?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

E4. Symbolic backlash

Have symbols important to your community (such as an Ambedkar statue or portrait) been damaged, removed, or opposed in your panchayat?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Have you faced opposition specifically when you tried to make people aware of their rights?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Enumerator: these are the most sensitive questions. Re-confirm consent first: "The next few questions are about serious situations. You may skip any of them." Do not probe for detail.

Since becoming mukhiya, have you received threats because of your work or your caste?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Have you or your family faced any physical harm or violence connected to your role?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Overall, how would you describe the difficulties you face because of your caste in this role?

- ☐ Very severe
- ☐ Severe
- ☐ Moderate
- ☐ Mild
- ☐ None

Module F — Victim-blaming

Enumerator: for each statement ask — has anyone said or suggested something like this to you?

That you brought your troubles on yourself by being too assertive.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

That politics or the mukhiya position is 'not for people like you.'

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

That you should step back, stay quiet, or let others handle things to avoid trouble.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

That the problems you face are your own fault for not cooperating with powerful people.

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Prefer not to say

Module G — Well-being (WHO-5)

(Read aloud) "Now a few general questions about how you have been feeling recently. Please think about the last two weeks."
Read the scale: 5 = All of the time, 4 = Most of the time, 3 = Some of the time, 2 = Rarely, 1 = Never.

» **Over the last two weeks...**

I have felt cheerful and in good spirits.



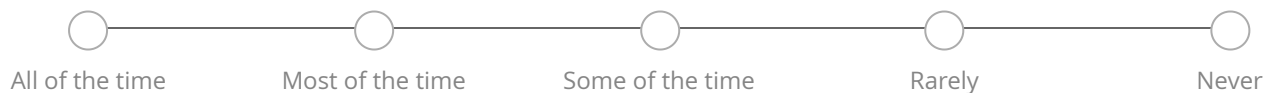
I have felt calm and relaxed.



I have felt active and vigorous.



I woke up feeling fresh and rested.



My daily life has been filled with things that interest me.



Module H — Closing

Is there anything about your experience as a mukhiya that you feel is important and that I have not asked about?

Enumerator: thank the respondent warmly, reconfirm confidentiality, and share support resources if any distress was shown.

Enumerator: complete the following yourself — do not ask the respondent.

How well did the respondent understand the questions?

- ☐ Fully
- ☐ Mostly
- ☐ Somewhat
- ☐ Poorly

How sincerely did the respondent answer?

- ☐ Fully sincere
- ☐ Mostly
- ☐ Somewhat
- ☐ Doubtful

Do you think the respondent was an independently acting mukhiya?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ Can't say

Please enter any other comments regarding this survey.
